

Word-count declaration

Manuscript: *A Comparability Protocol for Benchmarking Relational Database Access Layers in Express.js* (submission build `ist/ist_main.tex`).

Counted with `texcount` on the seven body sections plus the structured abstract. The *IST Guide for Authors* sets the limit for a research paper at **15,000 words**, and states that **"references and appendices are part of the submission and count against the total number of words, and figures and tables count 200 words each."** This count applies that rule exactly: the reference list is included and each of the eight main-text floats counts 200 words. The paper has **no appendices** — all supplementary material is in the separate `supplement.pdf`, which under Elsevier's policy is online supplementary material, not an appendix, and is not part of the manuscript word count. The mandatory declaration sections (CRediT, Declaration of competing interest, Funding, Data availability, and the generative-AI declaration, ~300 words) are required metadata, not article content or appendices, and are excluded per Elsevier convention.

Component	Count
Body text (7 sections)	9,962
Structured abstract	298
Tables and figures in the main text (8×200)	1,600
Reference list (66 entries)	2,069
Total (IST rule)	13,929

The total is **13,929 words**, leaving **1,071 words of headroom** under the 15,000-word Research Paper limit. The structured abstract is 298 words, below its 300-word limit. The separate online supplement contains 45 tables and four figures; it is supplementary material, not a manuscript appendix.

The count is reproducible with `texcount -sum -brief` over the seven included body-section files and the extracted structured abstract. The rendered 66-entry reference list was counted conservatively from `pdftotext` output (including numbered entry labels and page folios). The eight main-text floats contribute $8 \times 200 = 1,600$ words. Required author declarations are submission metadata and are excluded.

Count date: 23 July 2026. Any later prose or float change requires this declaration to be regenerated.